

“Today you are you, that is truer than true. There is no one alive who is youer than you.”

Dr. Seuss



How identity evolves

Young children usually talk about their identity in terms of their appearance and what they do—for example, their hair color or favorite sport. Older children tend to compare their identities to others. A child might start to feel good about their talents or bad about their perceived weaknesses.

During adolescence, teens generally gain a more complex sense of who they are. They might explain themselves in greater depth—for example, that they are cheerful and optimistic, but that doesn't mean they don't feel down sometimes. Many teens experiment to find out which identity feels real to them. As they encounter new people and new ideas, they learn, and their interests and views develop—all of which contribute to their evolving identity.



△ A gradual process

Although teens think a lot about who they are, their identity is fluid and will continue to change into adulthood.

When identities clash

Although family members may have some things in common, it's also completely normal for them to have very different perspectives on life. Sometimes teens and parents can feel as if they don't understand each other or can't agree on anything. When clashes happen, it's usually due to different personal values that make it hard for each side to understand the other. Acknowledging and accepting the differing values can make it easier to talk things through and get along.



▷ Changing perspective

Teens often seek fresh perspectives on topics such as music or politics in an effort to separate themselves from the identity their parents created for them when they were younger.